



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Covenant Christian School

School Website: <https://ccssmyrna.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Classicality Audit: Candeo Schools (Peoria, AZ)

Website audited: <https://candeoschools.com/>

Executive Summary

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Candeo Schools presents a robust classical profile in mission, goals, curriculum, faculty culture, and parent partnership. Its public materials consistently invoke key classical ideals—truth, goodness, beauty; wisdom and virtue; wonder; the liberal arts of the Trivium; Latin; and teacher-led formation. Notable strengths include explicit Trivium framing, Latin in 4–8, formal logic in middle school, memorization/recitation in the grammar years, and a stated partnership with families. The school aligns with Core Knowledge (content-rich sequence) and is a Hillsdale College Curriculum School, further reinforcing a classical content orientation. Evidence of Socratic pedagogy appears in hiring materials.

Two caveats temper the aggregate rating. First, as a classical charter, Candeo's public materials do not integrate theological study or liturgical practices, leaving the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category only partially satisfied. Second, the pedagogy pages prominently emphasize rigor, results, and performance language, which the classical "scholé/restful learning" tradition flags as potential counter-signals when they dominate.

Key strengths: - Clear commitment to "wisdom and virtue," "truth, goodness, and beauty," and formation (not mere information). - Trivium named; Latin in grades 4–8; formal logic in middle school; "history" (not "social studies") and Great Books references in hiring pages. - Consistent emphasis on memorization, recitation, and wonder in the lower school. - Explicit "partnership with families" in core values and a parents section welcoming collaboration and visits/tours.

Primary gaps: - No public evidence of theological integration or liturgical practices (a key part of the "Six Elements" metaphysical/religious foundation). - Heavy "rigor/results-driven" emphasis offsets "scholé/restful learning" signaling in pedagogy.

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- Positive matches found on-site: "truth, goodness, and beauty," "wisdom," "virtue," "wonder" (mission/philosophy/parents pages).

- No explicit matches for theology, catechesis, chapel, prayer, liturgy in public pages reviewed.
- Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
- Positive indicators expected include “truth, goodness, beauty,” “virtue,” “wisdom,” “wonder” (transcendental moral realism) and also theological grounding and liturgical practices.
- Candeo shows strong transcendental moral realism language but lacks public evidence of theology integration or liturgical/community worship practices (a frequent hallmark in classical Christian contexts).
- Quantitative estimate:
- Positive keyword hits (site): 7 (truth, goodness, beauty [multiple], virtue, wisdom, wonder).
- Negative keyword hits (site): 0 (no “values-neutral,” “secular humanism,” etc., explicitly present on-site).
- Percent positive: 100%
- Percent coverage (of sub-areas: moral realism, theology, liturgy): 60% (moral realism present; theology/liturgy not evidenced).
- Pos/Neg hits: +7/-0
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale: Clear transcendental moral realism, but no public evidence of theological study or liturgical practices per the “Six Elements” benchmarks.

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- “Grow wisdom and virtue for a life well lived,” “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty,” “education is formative,” “wonder,” “moral formation” (mission/philosophy/parents/core values).
- Minimal “college/workforce” emphasis; school notes college prep downstream but primarily emphasizes formation and virtue.
- Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
- Positive: cultivation of wisdom and virtue; pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty; formation not information.
- Negative: “college and career ready,” “workforce preparation,” “standardized testing focus” as primary goals (not prominent in Candeo’s purpose language).
- Quantitative estimate:
- Positive hits: 6 (wisdom, virtue, truth, goodness, beauty, formation).
- Negative hits: 1 (state testing logistics appear in handbook but not as a purpose emphasis).
- Percent positive: 86%
- Percent coverage: 100%
- Pos/Neg hits: +6/-1
- Rating: CLASSICAL

Rationale: Goals clearly center on formation in wisdom/virtue guided by truth, goodness, beauty—core classical telos.

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- Trivium defined (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric); students “analyze,” “grapple with ideas,” and produce “beautiful works in writing and speech” (Curriculum & Instruction).
- Latin (Grades 4–8); formal logic in middle school; rhetoric skills development noted.
- History and geography (not “social studies”); World and American History explicitly named (elementary).
- Great Books/Classics and Socratic experience singled out in hiring preferences.
- Hillsdale K–12 Curriculum affiliation; Core Knowledge content sequence (content-rich and cumulative).
- Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
- Positive: Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium), Great Books/primary texts, integrated humanities, cultivation of wonder.
- Candeo aligns with multiple positives (Trivium, Latin, logic/rhetoric, history, Great Books in hiring, wonder) and avoids signal negatives (e.g., substituting “social studies” for “history”).
- Quantitative estimate:
- Positive hits: 8 (Trivium, logic, rhetoric, Latin, history, Great Books, integration with Hillsdale, wonder).
- Negative hits: 0.
- Percent positive: 100%
- Percent coverage: 100%
- Pos/Neg hits: +8/-0
- Rating: CLASSICAL

Rationale: Core classical content elements are explicit and strong, with frequent direct matches to the lexicon (Trivium, Latin, history, Great Books).

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- Grammar-stage “memorization, recitation” and the trivium stages (logic: “analyze, ask good questions”; rhetoric: “clarity, persuasion, beauty”).
- “Daily time and space to... wonder” (elementary).
- Hiring materials value “Socratic teaching” and experience with “Great Books and Classics” (direct match to dialectic/seminar).
- Counter-signals: repeated emphasis on “rigorous,” “results-driven,” “top results,” “no-excuses,” testing/assessments, standards-based grading (less “scholé”/restful learning tone).
- Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
- Positive: Socratic/dialectic, restful learning (scholé), memorization/recitation, imitation/practice, upper-school rhetoric speaking opportunities.

- Negative (lack of scholé): “academic rigor,” “performance-driven,” “measurable outcomes” when dominating school discourse.
- Quantitative estimate:
- Positive hits: 6 (memorization, recitation, wonder, logic, rhetoric, Socratic).
- Negative hits: 6 (rigorous, results-driven, top results, no-excuses, standards-based grading, state/norm-referenced tests).
- Percent positive: 50%
- Percent coverage: 75% (K–8 model means limited explicit upper-school seminars; still shows Socratic in hiring).
- Pos/Neg hits: +6/-6
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale: Clear classical pedagogical markers (memorization/recitation, dialectic tendencies), though the strongly “results/rigor” framing dilutes the scholé/restful signal set in official language.

Note on K–8 scope: Absence of upper-school seminars is not disqualifying per the guidance that Socratic seminars typically begin in high school; evidence in hiring and middle-school logic/rhetoric is consistent with a classical K–8 approach.

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- “Teachers and leaders actively cultivate an environment of intellectual and moral virtue,” “lead with purpose” (faculty as moral/intellectual models).
- Ongoing coaching, mentoring, professional development; specialized teacher preparation program; collegial culture (“gathering room”).
- Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
- Positive: teachers as models of virtue, mentorship/collegiality, faculty formation in classical pedagogy.
- Quantitative estimate:
- Positive hits: 5 (virtue formation, mentorship/coaching, collegiality, purpose, faculty formation).
- Negative hits: 0.
- Percent positive: 100%
- Percent coverage: 70% (no published “portrait of a teacher”/“faculty of friends” found, but strong indications present).
- Pos/Neg hits: +5/-0
- Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY

- Evidence and keyword inventory from Candeo:
- Core value: “Partnership with Families – Walking alongside parents...”; mission pages emphasize “partnership”.

- Parents section and “Take a Tour” options (open campus visits and welcoming posture).
 - Comparison to “Six Elements” indicators:
 - Positive: parent partnership/co-educators; communication with families about philosophy; hospitable/open community.
 - No clear evidence (yet) of parent formation/book studies, but the partnership language is strong.
 - Quantitative estimate:
 - Positive hits: 4 (parent partnership, family collaboration, open tours, parent page/communications).
 - Negative hits: 0.
 - Percent positive: 100%
 - Percent coverage: 80% (parent formation events not identified).
 - Pos/Neg hits: +4/-0
 - Rating: CLASSICAL
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Overall Assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Candeo Schools meets most classical indicators across mission, goal, curriculum, faculty, and parent partnership. The two areas moderating the overall rating are (1) the absence of theological/liturgical integration in public materials (a major subcomponent of the “Religious and Metaphysical Foundations” in the Six Elements framework), and (2) mixed pedagogy signaling where substantial “rigor/results” language softens the “scholé/restful learning” emphasis.

- Aggregate call: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with strong potential to present as fully CLASSICAL within the constraints of a K–8 charter model if pedagogical communications and metaphysical foundations are clarified in ways consistent with the framework.
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What would move the needle

- Make restful learning explicit: Add language and examples of scholé/restful learning (e.g., contemplative reading, slow learning practices, festina lente) alongside rigor, to balance performance framing and align with classical pedagogy signals.
 - Show Socratic practice in action: Publish sample lesson snapshots or video clips demonstrating middle-school Socratic discussions/seminars and rhetoric exercises (debates, speeches), not just hiring preferences.
 - Highlight chanting/singing/recitation: Include concrete examples of lower-school chant and song (memory work recordings, classroom clips, or curriculum maps with recitation lists) to reinforce classical memory pedagogy.
 - Expand faculty formation narrative: Share a brief “portrait of a teacher” and “portrait of a graduate,” and note regular faculty colloquia/book seminars in classical texts to signal a “faculty of friends” and ongoing classical formation.
 - Deepen metaphysical clarity (charter-appropriate): While theological/liturgical integration may not be feasible, Candeo could still articulate its metaphysical commitments (objective moral order, natural law, the reality of the transcendentals) in a philosophically rich, non-sectarian manner to strengthen Element 1 coverage.
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Detailed Keyword Crosswalks (selected)

- Direct positive matches in Candeo materials: “wisdom,” “virtue,” “truth, goodness, and beauty,” “wonder,” “Trivium,” “Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric,” “Latin,” “memorization,” “recitation,” “Socratic”.
- Direct negative or counter-signals present: “rigorous,” “results-driven,” “top results,” “no-excuses,” “assessments/standardized” (tone that can counter “scholé/restful learning” when dominant).

References for the keyword standards used above are drawn from the Six Elements keyword lists and lexicon covering all six categories (e.g., TGB/virtue/wisdom; Trivium/Great Books/Latin; Socratic/scholé/chanting; faculty as mentors/models; parent partnership).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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